

Chapter 73-1

The agent's question left Liang Shi stumped.

Were they newlyweds?

It seemed like they were.

But it also seemed like they weren't.

Her and Xu Qingzhu's current state was very much like roommates, and roommates who got along extremely well at that.

Xu Qingzhu and the original body were newlyweds.

.....

Thinking this way, Liang Shi's heart actually felt a bit sour.

It was Xu Qingzhu beside her who asked: "How much is this apartment per month?"

The agent immediately answered: "Eight thousand five hundred, deposit one month, pay three months."

"Are apartments in this complex this expensive?" Xu Qingzhu frowned, "My friend rented an apartment in Jingyu District that's bigger than this one, only seven thousand per month."

"The location here is good." The agent said, "Don't look at this apartment as unremarkable, but turn one street corner and you're at the commercial center, it backs onto the Procuratorate¹, and walk forward two more streets and you have the international bilingual kindergarten and Haizhou First High School—a genuine school district property."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

She frowned: "Haizhou City First High School?"

"That's Huaxing Middle School." The agent said, "Huaxing Middle School's junior high division now has the best enrollment rate in the entire city."

"The First High School is No. 1 High." Xu Qingzhu said, "No. 1 High is on Fanrong Street."

"That's such old news." The agent laughed, "No. 1 High's enrollment rate is terrible now. Huaxing Middle School's undergraduate rate reaches 95% every year."

"Really?" Xu Qingzhu suddenly paused, "What about Huai'an Private School?"

The agent thought for a moment, "That's all a school wealthy people go to, a noble school. How many students inside are there to seriously study?"

Xu Qingzhu hesitated for a moment, "Is transferring schools troublesome now?"

The agent: "That depends on what grade you're in."

"Sophomore year." Xu Qingzhu said, "Just promoted. Her grades are pretty good too."

Standing to the side listening quietly, Liang Shi: "....."

Never expected that just coming to look at an apartment, Xu Qingzhu would actually think about transferring schools for Xu Qingya.

However, they didn't reach an agreement afterward. When the agent said Huai'an Private School was too trashy, not even producing one student admitted to Qingyi University² every year, Xu Qingzhu scoffed disdainfully.

Though she didn't say anything.

However, this apartment fell through—they didn't reach an agreement.

The agent took them to see a few more, but none were very satisfactory.

After leaving that complex, Xu Qingzhu looked at the luxurious exterior of the residential area and said faintly: "Gilt and jade on the outside, rot and decay on the inside³."

Liang Shi: "....."

They did completely give up the idea of finding an apartment in this complex though, shifting their focus to locations between both their companies.

Mainly to be closer to Minghui.

Liang Shi would very likely not work at Dongheng for much longer, so the apartment's geographical location should serve Xu Qingzhu as much as possible.

Footnotes:

¹ Procuratorate (检察院): In China, the People's Procuratorate is a government agency responsible for prosecution and legal supervision, similar to a prosecutor's office in Western countries. Living near such an institution is considered prestigious and safe.

² Qingyi University (青翼大学): A fictional prestigious university in this novel. The name literally means "Green Wing University."

³ Gilt and jade on the outside, rot and decay on the inside (金玉其外,败絮其中): A Chinese idiom meaning something that looks impressive on the outside but is worthless or rotten inside. It's used to describe things or people that are superficially attractive but lack substance.

Chapter 73-2

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In the dream, it was like an endless abyss, with her entire being continuously falling downward.

The entire world was pitch black.

Suddenly, the falling stopped.

A beam of light fell in a corner, dust particles dancing in the air. In the corner appeared a little girl with pigtails. Her head was buried in her knees, looking pitiful and alone.

Su Yao sat across from her, separated by a distance of several meters.

Su Yao felt her heart being wrenched with pain, brimming with indescribable sourness.

She reached out her hand, wanting to touch that child, but all she touched was empty air.

Yet she could clearly see that child.

After a while, the child lifted her head, but her face was a mass of pixels¹, completely obscuring her features.

Su Yao was confused and bewildered, asking sadly: "Who are you?"

The child opened and closed her mouth. Her mouth became visible, then her nose, her eyes—a face that looked very familiar.

It was a face she had seen during the day.

Her face was completely mismatched with her body, looking extremely incongruous.

But after seeing her, Su Yao just kept shedding tears.

The child spoke: "Why didn't you come find me?"

"I'm so sad." That tender, childish voice carried resentment, "I've had such a hard time."

"Mommy... what are you doing?"

"Are you my mommy? Come find me."

"....."

The childish voice became more and more miserable, more and more resentful. Just like it had appeared countless times in dreams before, she began to wail loudly.

During this, Sheng Qinglin's voice was also mixed in: "Yaoyao, look at little Zhuzi², she smiles so adorably."

"She looks like you, she'll definitely be beautiful when she grows up."

"Let's call her Qingzhu³, unbending and unbreakable, forever verdant⁴."

"She was born by you, of course she should take your surname."

"....."

Too many voices mixed together—she couldn't hear clearly at all.

At this moment, the Su family villa was in complete chaos.

The cause was that Sheng Yu woke up thirsty in the middle of the night and wanted water. She wanted to find a servant without disturbing her mother, but when going out the door she tripped and fell directly onto the carpet. Still not fully awake, she was in so much pain she wanted to cry, sniffing pitifully for a while.

Normally, her mother would have already woken up.

But when she drank water and returned to the room, quietly climbing onto the bed planning to continue sleeping, she heard her mother crying.

She pushed her mother, but there was no response.

Her mother's tears only fell more and more. Then her mother turned over, burying her entire head in the pillow, continuing to sob.

Sheng Yu was terrified and immediately burst into loud wails, startling everyone in the villa.

But the only person who wasn't awakened by the crying was Su Yao.

The family doctor summoned from abroad immediately held a consultation and discovered Su Yao had fallen into a deep nightmare.

In this situation, they couldn't rashly wake her. She was already mentally fragile—if they rashly woke her, who knew what serious consequences might occur.

The family doctor attempted to gently rouse her, but found it had no effect.

This startled everyone in the household.

Su Meiqi felt afraid in her heart. Then Sheng Yu cried beside her saying: "It must be because mommy was bullied by bad people today that she's crying."

"Bullied?" Su Zhe immediately interrogated: "By whom?"

Su Meiqi didn't let little Sheng Yu speak about this matter. Instead, she pulled her father into the study and laid out everything about encountering Xu Qingzhu at Minghui's entrance today. Then she asked in confusion: "What's her relationship with Auntie?"

Su Meiqi frowned: "She doesn't seem like Sheng Qinglin's niece, more like his daughter. And acting as if my aunt abandoned her."

Su Zhe: "....."

"You just saw Xu Qingzhu?" Su Zhe asked.

Su Meiqi nodded: "And her wife too."

"That good-for-nothing playboy?" Just mentioning her, Su Zhe's eyes were full of disdain.

Su Meiqi shook her head: "She's already reformed. Now she treats Sister Xu really well. The two of them are quite loving."

Su Zhe scoffed lightly, making no comment on this.

"First tell me, does Xu Qingzhu have a relationship with Auntie or not?" Su Meiqi asked again.

Su Zhe nodded: "She is your aunt's daughter."

Su Meiqi: "!"

"Then Auntie....." Su Meiqi paused, confused: "How did she suddenly remember?"

Su Zhe sighed: "She was triggered."

However, Su Zhe belatedly realized: "So Xu Qingzhu knew and came to condemn your aunt?"

"Can't really call it condemnation." Su Meiqi recalled her afternoon attitude, "She was very aggressive."

Su Zhe: "....."

"What gives her the right?" Su Zhe said angrily, "What does she even know?"

He originally wanted to curse, but thinking that back then Xu Qingzhu was just a baby who knew nothing, he had to let it go.

It just made that feeling of wanting to drag out the old Sheng couple and flog their corpses⁵ even stronger.

Every time Su Yao had an episode, Su Zhe wanted to flog their corpses once.

He even wanted to grab them by the collar and ask, "If your son whose bones aren't even cold yet could see this, do you think he could die with his eyes closed⁶?"

Driving his beloved to madness and snatching away his daughter to give her someone else's surname.

What idiotic parents.

Footnotes:

¹ Pixels/mosaic (马赛克): In Chinese internet culture, this term (literally "mosaic") refers to pixelation or blurring used to obscure images, similar to how faces are censored on TV.

² Little Zhuzi (小竹子): A nickname meaning "little bamboo." This is significant as it relates to Xu Qingzhu's name.

³ Qingzhu (青竹): Literally means "green/blue bamboo." This is Xu Qingzhu's given name.

⁴ Unbending and unbreakable, forever verdant (不屈不折,永远青翠): This describes the characteristics of bamboo in Chinese culture—resilience, strength, and evergreen vitality. Bamboo is one of the "Four Gentlemen" in Chinese art, symbolizing integrity and moral fortitude.

⁵ Flog their corpses (鞭尸): A Chinese expression meaning to severely criticize or condemn someone (especially the dead) for their past wrongs, derived from the historical practice of literally whipping corpses as punishment.

⁶ Die with his eyes closed (死得瞑目): A Chinese idiom meaning to die content or at peace, with no regrets. The literal image is of someone able to close their eyes peacefully in death. Used negatively here to suggest Sheng Qinglin would be unable to rest peacefully knowing what happened to his wife and daughter.

Chapter 73-3

Su Meiqi was full of questions, but seeing that Su Zhe didn't look like he was going to give her answers, she awkwardly slipped away.

Meanwhile, the family doctor here was just wrapping up. Su Zhe came over just in time to hear Su Yao, on the verge of waking, cry out heart-wrenchingly: "Qingzhu!"

The entire room fell silent.

Then Su Yao woke up. She looked ahead in confusion, then stiffly turned her body toward Su Zhe. Those eyes were washed with tears again as she asked in a hoarse voice: "Brother, who exactly have I forgotten?"

She said through tears: "My heart hurts so much. She told me to remember, but I can't."

Sheng Yu had been taken to sleep by a servant, and Su Meiqi had also been sent away.

Only Su Zhe and the family doctor remained in the room.

Su Zhe sat there contemplating for a long while, finally sighing: "If you can't remember, then don't try to. Sooner or later, you'll remember."

"It's someone very, very important." Su Yao said, "I dreamed of the girl I met today. In the dream, Qinglin was holding her and saying, our daughter is Qingzhu¹, she should be like bamboo—unbending and unbreakable, forever verdant."

Su Zhe closed his eyes, suppressing all his sorrowful emotions, and told her rationally: "Your daughter is right here, isn't she? Sheng Yu is by your side."

Su Yao continued shaking her head, "Not Sheng Yu."

She suddenly grabbed Su Zhe's sleeve and asked: "Brother, do I have another daughter?"

Su Zhe: "....."

"That girl today." Su Yao gripped Su Zhe's arm tightly, hurting him, but Su Zhe didn't make a sound. Su Yao's state was on the edge of collapse, yet she tried desperately to stay lucid: "She looks so much like Qinglin, especially when she's angry, she really looks... she she she... I I I... Did she come to find me?"

"Don't be foolish." Su Zhe still said heartlessly: "That's Sheng Linlang's daughter. Isn't it normal for her to resemble Sheng Qinglin?"

"Sheng Linlang....." Su Yao murmured the name: "Sounds so familiar."

Su Zhe: "....."

Today Su Yao didn't remember Sheng Linlang again.

But after a long while, Su Yao suddenly said: "I remember now, she's Qinglin's older sister. I... I haven't visited her since returning."

"There's nothing worth visiting." Su Zhe gently coaxed: "Sheng Qinglin passed away so many years ago. If you go, you'll just stir up her bad memories. Better not to meet."

Su Yao was gradually persuaded.

But she asked repeatedly: "Do I have another daughter?"

Su Zhe patiently answered: "No, only Sheng Yu."

Footnotes:

¹ Qingzhu (青竹): This is a repetition of the name explanation from the previous chapter, emphasizing the significance of Xu Qingzhu's name meaning "green/blue bamboo" and its symbolic connection to her father Sheng Qinglin (whose name contains "Qing" 清) and the bamboo qualities he wished for her.

Chapter 73-4

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That same night, a quarrel also erupted at the Liang family villa.

After dinner ended, Sun Meirou took Ling Dang upstairs to wash up. Yu Wan had been especially prone to drowsiness lately. After saying goodbye to everyone, she went upstairs to rest.

Only the two Liang brothers and the Liang couple remained.

Qiu Zimin sat weakly on the sofa watching the news, while Father Liang and the Liang brothers went to the study to discuss company matters.

It wasn't until after nine o'clock that Qiu Zimin had a servant cut fruit, then personally delivered it to the study door, where she heard Father Liang talking to someone: "Are you certain? Those two people are from Taoyuan County¹? Then what about my daughter? Is she still there now?"

"What do you mean? They're all dead?" Just as Father Liang finished speaking, Qiu Zimin pushed open the door and said sternly: "Who died? Is my Nuan Nuan already dead?"

Father Liang waved his hand signaling her to calm down and continued talking with the person on the other end of the phone.

Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe exchanged glances, both seeing helplessness in each other's eyes.

They'd said every good and bad word possible, but this couple just wouldn't listen.

Finding their biological daughter had become their obsession.

Last time when Liang Shi brought Xu Qingzhu home for dinner, it also ended unpleasantly.

This family seemed to automatically exclude Liang Shi.

This left both Liang brothers feeling speechless yet powerless.

The strange atmosphere continued until Father Liang finished his call. As soon as he hung up, he found Qiu Zimin already in tears. He said helplessly: "What are you doing?"

"Our Nuan Nuan....." Qiu Zimin sobbed quietly, "Is she really dead?"

"She's not dead." Father Liang frowned and sighed lightly: "Her family is all dead."

Qiu Zimin immediately perked up. Father Liang had Liang Xinhe open his phone. Liang Xinhe was bewildered: "What for?"

"Open that thing called Weibo²." Father Liang said, "That app. Search for Guo Xinran."

Liang Xinhe: "....."

"Xin is the 'xin' from 'xinwei'³, ran is the 'ran' from 'ranhou'⁴." Father Liang urged: "Hurry up."

Liang Xinhe was under pressure. Just as he was about to unlock his phone, Liang Xinzhou pressed it down. He looked at Father Liang: "Do you still remember what I told you?"

"I can understand you favoring Liang Shi, but the problem is your biological sister has no one left around her." Father Liang looked at him, "Liang Xinzhou, are you really that heartless?"

Liang Xinzhou's expression stiffened. He adjusted his glasses: "Can you come up with a strategy to protect everyone?"

"You're right, there will inevitably be sacrifices." Father Liang said in a heavy voice: "Just let....."

Qiu Zimin spoke first: "Sacrificing Liang Shi will do. This family is the same with or without her. She's an ungrateful wretch⁵. Now she's even turning around to bite me. I'm already putting the Qianshui Bay villa up for sale. From now on, she shouldn't associate with the Liang family—bad luck."

Qiu Zimin looked at the two brothers with reddened eyes: "I'm telling you both, if you have any brotherly love, show more care for your biological sister! Can't you hear? Your biological sister is suffering. You're all heartless people."

As she spoke, she ran out to get her own phone, then searched for that name in the living room. She saw her pinned Weibo post and those posted photos. She stumbled back to the study, then said to Father Liang: "It's her, it's her."

Father Liang was currently in a standoff with the Liang brothers.

Liang Xinhe's opinion was that they could have both. Liang Xinzhou's meaning was to just give money and not bring the person back.

Father Liang clearly agreed more with Liang Xinhe's opinion, but also implicitly suggested giving Liang Shi her own business, just giving Liang Shi a sum of money to make her disappear from public view and stop associating with the Liang family.

Meanwhile, Qiu Zimin was still in shock from finding her daughter. Seeing the three of them with gloomy faces in confrontation, her anger flared up. She pointed at the Liang brothers and said furiously: "That's your biological sister! What is Liang Shi? We raised her well enough! What are you doing now? Are you going to sever ties with the Liang family for her sake?"

"Mom, you're being too extreme." Liang Xinhe came out to mediate: "Aren't we discussing a better strategy? Liang Shi can stay, and that sister can be brought back too."

"I still say the same thing—bringing her back makes her a ticking time bomb." Liang Xinzhou said: "Who knows when she'll blow up our entire family."

"You haven't even met her in person, how can you be so arbitrary?!" Qiu Zimin said sternly: "Liang Xinzhou, I think you've been bewitched by Liang Shi!"

"This has nothing to do with her as a person." Liang Xinzhou stood up, looking down at Qiu Zimin. After thinking for two seconds, he said coldly: "It's your attitude that tells me."

Liang Xinzhou said: "Look at yourself now, and your recent behavior. Ever since you argued with Liang Shi, you've been like this every day. If you found your biological daughter, you would definitely make everyone yield to her, but I'm not willing to let my family yield to her, even if she's suffered and struggled outside for many years."

"Slap—"

Qiu Zimin slapped Liang Xinzhou across the face, directly knocking off his glasses. She screamed: "Liang Xinzhou, are those human words coming out of your mouth?!"

"Why are you so selfish?!" Qiu Zimin demanded: "That's your biological sister! She nearly died outside all these years, and it's not right for the whole family to yield to her? What kind of spell has Liang Shi cast on you to make you hate me like this? Do you want to replace me as your mother too?!"

Liang Xinzhou was stunned for a moment.

Then he looked at Qiu Zimin coldly.

That cold gaze made Qiu Zimin shiver, suddenly realizing what she had just done.

Qiu Zimin's hand trembled slightly.

Had she hit her son who was this grown?

Hit for the first time this son who had made her incredibly proud since childhood?

Liang Xinzhou's voice nearly froze into ice as he said in a low voice: "These years, you and Father know in your hearts what you've done to Liang Shi. You used her, then you want to throw her away."

Liang Xinzhou curved his lips in a cold smile: "Then bring your biological daughter back. Fine, go ahead."

"She comes back, I move out." Liang Xinzhou said: "This is your home, do as you please."

A naked threat.

"Liang Xinzhou, you!" Qiu Zimin was about to reprimand him when Liang Xinzhou had already stepped on his own glasses and walked out, leaving only his back view.

Liang Xinhe said helplessly: "I'll go try to persuade him."

After saying this, he also left the study.

But after they left, Qiu Zimin looked at Father Liang and suddenly covered her face and wept bitterly: "What sins have I committed?"

Father Liang was silent for a moment, then sighed: "Let's find Nuan Nuan first."

Footnotes:

¹ Taoyuan County (桃源县): A county name, literally means "Peach Blossom Spring County," referencing the famous Chinese literary work about an isolated utopia.

² Weibo (微博): China's equivalent of Twitter, a major social media platform for microblogging.

³ Xinwei (欣慰): Meaning "gratified" or "relieved"—Father Liang is using this word to indicate which character "xin" (欣) to use.

⁴ Ranhou (然后): Meaning "then" or "after that"—Father Liang is using this to indicate which character "ran" (然) to use.

⁵ Ungrateful wretch/white-eyed wolf (白眼狼): A Chinese idiom referring to someone who is ungrateful and betrays those who helped them, like a wolf that cannot be domesticated and will turn on its benefactors.